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Trump's diesel threat risks hurting European truckers — and raising prices for consumers

By Martina Sapio · Oct 1, 2026, 5:29 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — Donald Trump's threat to halt U.S. diesel exports could leave Europe's truckers facing another sharp rise in fuel costs — and consumers paying more for goods.

The U.S. president said Wednesday that he is still “thinking about” an export ban as his administration tries to bring down record fuel prices at home. The White House is also checking if European countries could release their diesel reserves to lower prices.

More expensive diesel could have a knock-on impact across Europe. “Everything on the shelf will cost more,” said Cristina Scarfia, head of European affairs at Italian freight federation Confetra.

Europe has grown increasingly reliant on American diesel after war, shipping disruption and refinery outages sharply reduced supplies from the Middle East and Russia. That reliance is now leaving Europe's truckers exposed in an industry that already runs on thin margins and has little room to absorb another shock.

“There is a huge risk of bankruptcies” for small and medium-sized companies, said Scarfia. Larger companies are more likely to survive by charging more for their services, she added.

The average EU diesel price reached €2.26 per liter on Sept. 17 — 38% higher than in late February, according to the International Road Transport Union . It's a new record, topping the previous high set during the 2022 energy crisis sparked by Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

Confetra estimates that a U.S. export ban could push diesel prices well above €3 per liter in the EU, Scarfia said.

Running out of options

As Middle Eastern exports have fallen following the U.S.-Israeli war against Iran, which has disrupted fuel shipments through the Strait of Hormuz, Europe has increasingly turned to the U.S. to fill the gap. American diesel now accounts for roughly half of Europe's seaborne imports, according to IRU figures. If Washington bans those exports, road freight would be especially exposed.

David Doherty, head of natural resources research at strategic research provider BloombergNEF, said that logistics is Europe's biggest diesel user. Transport accounts for 77% of EU diesel and gas oil consumption, according to Eurostat .

“There’s really limited, at least quick, alternatives there,” Doherty said. “You and me can decide to stop driving if the prices get really high and the world is not going to fall apart. If there’s no trucks operating around Germany or Poland, the two biggest markets, you’ll probably start to see pain points.”

“The knock-on effects go far beyond just expensive diesel,” Doherty said. “It could be no diesel in the right place, it could be long refills, it could be queues.” Hours spent waiting for fuel would also eat into the time drivers have left to actually deliver goods.

The biggest pressure on trucking companies is likely to be financial.

Diesel makes up roughly 30% of the cost of running an international trucking company, according to Jan Buczek, president of Poland’s Association of International Road Transport Carriers. If diesel prices climb high enough, some trips simply stop making financial sense — and companies can run out of the cash they need to keep going.

Trucking companies have to pay for diesel, wages and tolls up front, Buczek added, but payment from customers for a completed job can take weeks to arrive. A sudden jump in fuel prices could create an immediate cash crunch — meaning bills come due before the money to cover them does.

“At diesel prices of around €3 per liter, the risk that some operators go under would be very real, particularly if prices stayed at that level for a prolonged period,” Buczek said.

Small and medium-sized companies are the most exposed. They typically have smaller cash reserves, less access to credit and less leverage with customers than large logistics groups — and they’d be heading into a new diesel shock already weakened. More than 1,000 companies have already disappeared from Poland’s international trucking market this year, Buczek added.

Park the truck

For companies that survive, the next question is who pays the higher fuel bill.

On the spot market — where a company books a single truck for one shipment rather than signing a longer-term contract — higher diesel prices show up almost immediately. Trucking companies demand higher rates, and if customers won’t pay, some trips simply stop making financial sense.

“No company can continue providing services below cost for an extended period of time,” Buczek said.

Trucking companies would likely get pickier about which jobs they take. The first to go would be the lowest-paying ones — routes with long stretches of empty driving, destinations where it’s hard to find cargo for the trip back, and jobs that involve long waits to load or unload.

“If the cost of providing the service exceeds the revenue generated by it, from the operator’s perspective it may be economically more rational to leave the truck parked than to generate another loss,” Buczek added.

Scarfia described two likely outcomes. Smaller companies, unable to pass on higher diesel costs, may simply turn down jobs, forcing customers to find someone else. Larger companies are more likely to have contracts that let them add a fuel surcharge — an extra fee tied to the price of diesel — so they can keep moving goods while passing the added cost on to clients.

If extremely high prices lasted for weeks, and actual fuel shortages set in too, Buczek said Europe could start to see less trucking capacity on some routes, have trouble finding available trucks, and encounter delays rippling through supply chains.

For trucking companies, the impact would be “significant and certainly immediate,” said Robin Loos, head of transport and mobility at consumer organization BEUC.

“If transport capacity begins to disappear from the market, the consequences very quickly extend beyond the road transport industry itself,” Buczek said.

At that point, he added, diesel supply will become a matter of “economic security.”

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